

The Colosseum

The largest ever Roman amphitheater, which has become an iconic symbol of the city of Rome

The Colosseum was built in the 1st century CE as part of a regeneration of the city after the death of the disgraced Emperor Nero. It was commissioned by his successor Vespasian in 72 CE and was opened in 80 CE. A place of entertainment, it provided a huge space for combat between gladiators and animals, reconstructions of battles and mythical episodes, and public executions.

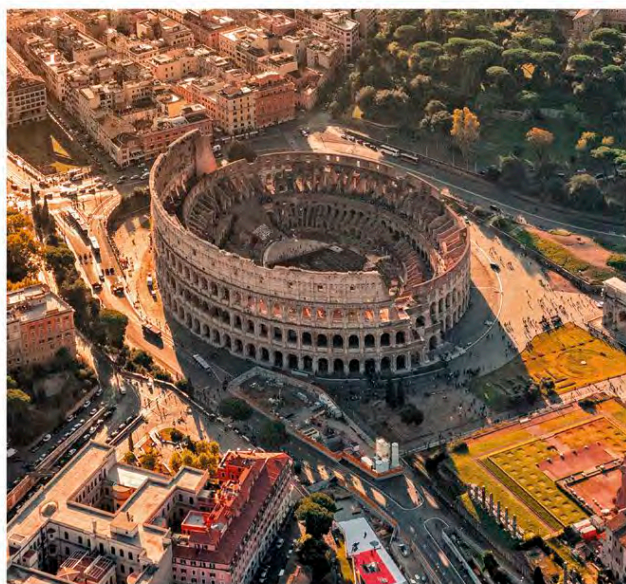
Building on a grand scale

The Colosseum was constructed mainly from local limestone with some internal brickwork. It reached a height of 159 ft (48.5 m) and covered an elliptical area

that was 617 ft (188 m) long and 512 ft (156 m) wide. The exterior of the structure features Doric, Ionic, and Corinthian arcades, whose arches would have contained statues. The floor of the arena covered the hypogeum—a maze of tunnels and chambers to house the participants in the games held above.

The amphitheater fell into disrepair after 404 CE, when the games were abolished, and over time suffered from damage by earthquakes, neglect, and looting. Despite occasional attempts at restoration, it was not until the 19th century that its architectural importance was fully recognized and the Colosseum preserved for posterity.

The Colosseum was designed to hold **more than 50,000 spectators**

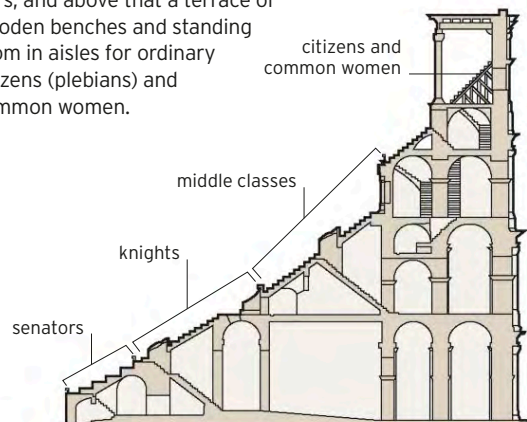


△ MAGNIFICENT RELIC

Although only half of the outer walls remain, the surviving entrance passages and hypogeum are enough to reveal the grandeur of its scale and the skill that went into its construction.

TIERED SEATING

The accommodation for spectators surrounding the arena was arranged in tiers, with separate levels for the various social classes. Ringside seats at the lower level were reserved for the emperor and senators; behind them was a zone for knights; then, the middle classes, separated into two tiers; and above that a terrace of wooden benches and standing room in aisles for ordinary citizens (plebians) and common women.



▷ LIMESTONE ARCHES

The exterior walls of the Colosseum comprise three stories of arcades decorated with half-columns and a plain fourth story with small, rectangular windows.

